

SUPERNATURAL HELPERS

witches' familiars

Spiritual helpers and the divine have long had links to the animal world, from the animal-headed gods of the ancient Egyptians to the *wayob* creature companions of the Maya. As the European witch craze of the 16th and 17th centuries grew in pace, the notion of the witch's familiar arose. Usually small domestic animals such as cats, frogs, and toads (occasionally even human), familiars were reputed to give their human partner supernatural abilities, allowing the witch to see through the creature's eyes or to transform herself into an animal and so gain access to forbidden areas.

Familiars were not necessarily considered to be evil. When attached to cunning folk or good witches, they tended to be viewed as kindly or even as animal embodiments of fairies. However, the common belief was that the Devil took the form of animal familiars, and so their supposed companionship became a key piece of evidence used to prove guilt during witch trials.

Signs of witchcraft

Confessions from British trials suggest that the arrival of the familiar often marked the induction of the witch into the world of evil magic: the animal appeared unbidden or at a time of great need. Witches were said to make a pact with their

familiar, guaranteeing its service for a period that might stretch to decades—a variant on the direct pact with Satan that witches were more commonly said to make outside Great Britain. In return, the witch nourished the familiar, and a witch's teat (an extra nipple or lump on the body) was often cited as a sign of evil magic. In the Salem witch trials (see p.189), one of the accused, Sarah Good, was said to have a yellow bird that sucked between her fingers.

Unexpected companions

Familiars were believed to be able to take unusual forms. Old Mother Samuel, hanged for witchcraft in 1593, had a chicken, and there are records in Northern Europe that tell of demonic flies buzzing around witches' heads.

Accusations of possessing familiars were usually directed at the vulnerable but might be pitted at political opponents: Prince Rupert of the Rhine, a royalist in the English Civil War, was said to have a canine familiar, Boy. The dog accompanied him into battle until it died at Marston Moor in 1644.



▲ Making mischief

The German legal scholar Ulrich Molitor advocated the killing of witches. In this illustration from his *On Witches and Female Soothsayers* (1489), he shows witches transforming themselves into animals.

IN PRACTICE

Magical cats



The cat **Sathan** featured in grotesque testimony that helped secure the conviction and execution of Elizabeth Francis.

Cats were the most commonly reported witch's familiar—there was even a medieval legend that the Devil had created them by accident. In the first major Elizabethan witch trial, held at Chelmsford in 1566, the accused, Elizabeth Francis, said she had inherited the familiar, a white spotted cat called Sathan, from her grandmother and later gave it to Agnes "Mother" Waterhouse, her codefendant. Feline familiars continued to be a feature of witchcraft accusations, and in 1662 Scotswoman Isobel Gowdie confessed that the Devil had given her the power to transform herself into a cat.